

Session 3: The Design of Genesis 1-11

Key Takeaways

- To understand a story's meaning, it is crucial to pay attention to its literary design shape.
- Knowing good and evil is about moral discernment and taking the authority to define good and bad by your own wisdom.
- In response to the rebellion of his appointed rulers and the outcry of innocent blood, God will allow the cosmos to sink back into chaos. But in his mercy, he rescues a remnant to share his world with so they can rule on his behalf.

The Story of Noah and the Flood In Genesis 1-11

The Noah story in Genesis 6-11 fits within a larger pattern at work in Genesis 1-11. Chapters 1-5 play out a cycle of themes, and chapters 6-11 replay and develop the cycle.

Unit		Theme
A1	1:1-2:3 Creation of sacred cosmos from chaos waters / human image of God / blessing / fruitful and multiply	Creation and Blessing
B1	2:4-3:24 Mountain-garden temple / sin, nakedness, curse, exile	Failure
B2	4:1-16 Next generation sins / brothers divide / firstborn not chosen / curse, exile	Failure of Next Generation
C1	4:17-26 Adam to Lemek: 7 generations + 3 sons / city of Cain / murder / 70 x 7	Non-Chosen
C2	5:1-32 Adam to Noah: 10 generations + 3 sons / promise of comfort	Chosen
B3	6:1-8 Cosmic rebellion in Heaven and Earth: sons of God invade the land, leading to the flood	Cosmic Rebellion
Macro-Design of Genesis 1-11. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Adam to Noah (2020).		

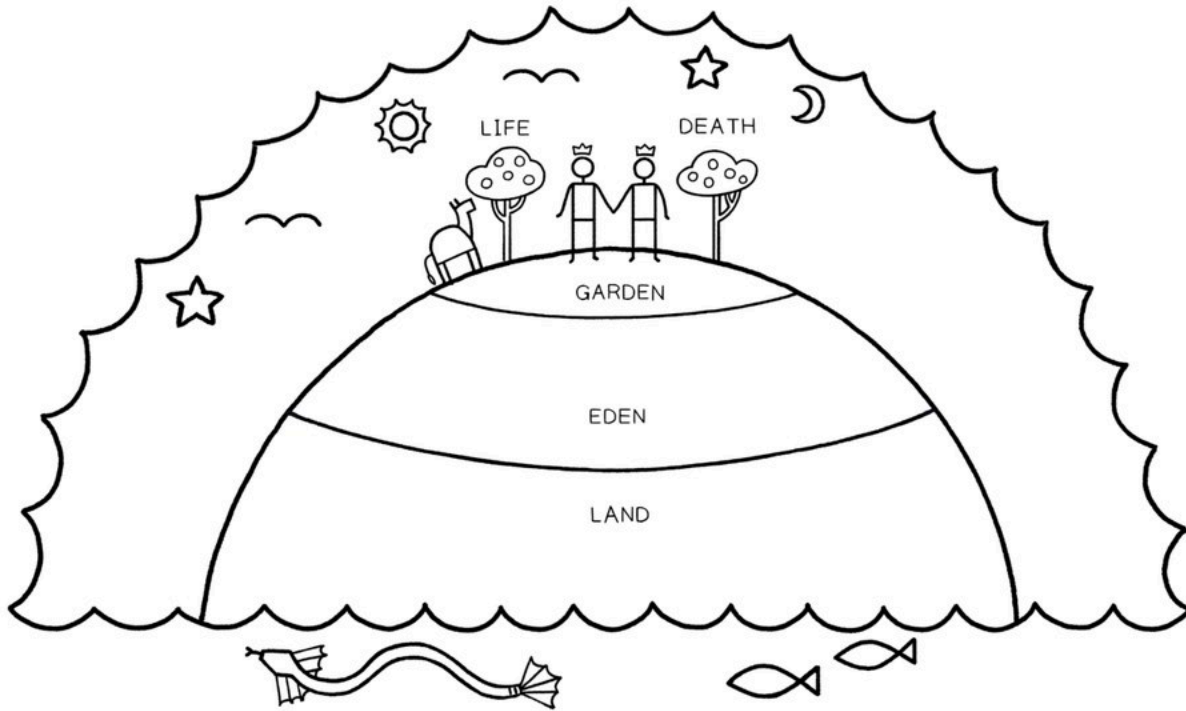
Genesis 1-3 as the Introduction to the TaNaK

"When understood as the introduction to the Torah and to the TaNaK as a whole, Genesis 1-3 intentionally foreshadows Israel's failure to keep the Sinai covenant as well as their exile from the promised land in order to point the reader to a future work of God in the "last days." Adam's failure to "conquer" (Gen. 1:28) the seditious inhabitant of the land (the serpent), his temptation and violation of the commandments, and his exile from the garden is Israel's story in miniature ... Just as it was in the beginning ... so it will be in the end. In the conclusion to the Pentateuch, Moses presents Israel's future apostasy and exile as a certainty (see Deut. 30:1-10) ... This inclusion of pessimism at both ends of the Pentateuch with respect to human abilities to "do this and live," not only supplies the context for interpreting the Sinai narrative, but also provides the rationale for the need of a new work in the "last days," whereby God will heal the human heart. Moreover, the groundwork is also laid for the expectation of another "Adam" (a future priest king) to arise from among the people of Israel who will fulfill the creation mandate in the last days. In other words, Genesis 1-3 ... forthrightly prepares the reader to expect that Israel will fail its covenant with God, and so to wait expectantly in exile for a new work of God in the last days."

Adapted from Postell, Seth (2011). [*Adam as Israel: Genesis 1-3 as the Introduction to the Torah and Tanakh*](#). Pickwick Publications.

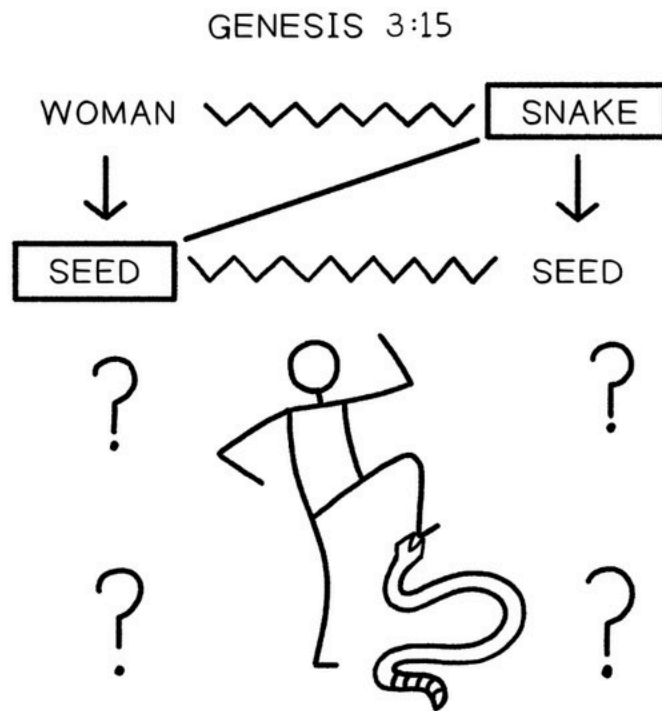
Genesis 1-11 Illustrated

The pattern of themes begins with God's ideal for creation. Humanity lives at peace with the animals and rules as God's representatives.



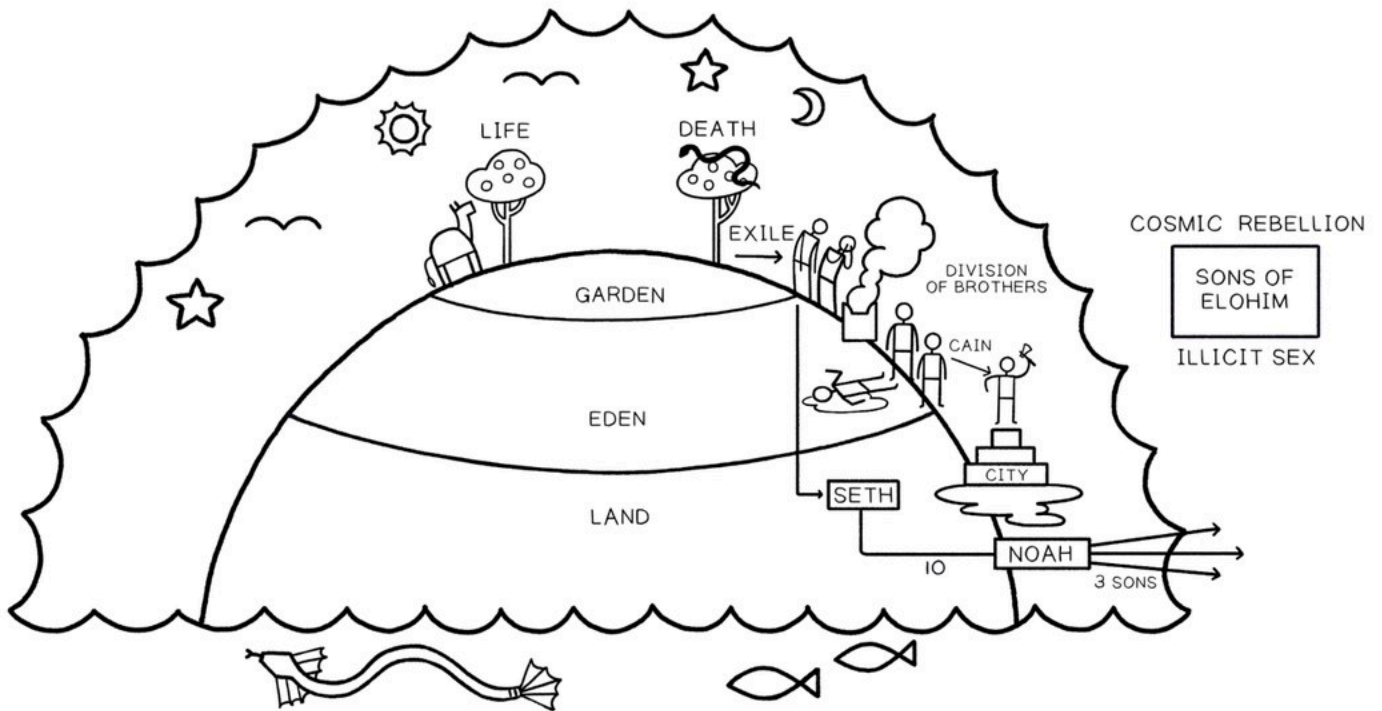
Ideal Creation. Illustration created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Noah to Abraham (2020).

After the failure in the garden, God promises that though there will be conflict between the seed of the woman and the seed of the snake, someday one of the woman's descendants will triumph over the snake.



Genesis 3:15 Snake Crusher. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Noah to Abraham (2020).

Still, the failure of humanity leads to exile from the garden. The failure and rebellion of the following generations lead to an escalation of violence and bloodshed.



From Adam to Noah's Three Sons. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Noah to Abraham (2020).

God's judgment and mercy are bound together as he rescues Noah and his family through the chaos waters of the flood. Noah offers a sacrifice on the high place in response to God's goodness, but the cycle of folly, division, and violence begins anew.